

LEO MINOR

THE LITTLE LION

A SMALL AND FAINT CONSTELLATION IN THE NORTHERN SKY REPRESENTING A LION CUB, LEO MINOR WAS INVENTED IN THE LATE 17TH CENTURY BY JOHANNES HEVELIUS.

Leo Minor is not one of the constellations known to the ancient Greeks but was introduced in 1687 by the Polish astronomer Johannes Hevelius. Squeezed into a gap between Leo and Ursa Major, it is easily overlooked. It has no star labeled Alpha, although there is a Beta. This is due to an error by the English astronomer Francis Baily, who omitted to label its brightest member, 46 Leonis Minoris, when cataloging its stars in 1845. The constellation's most famous object is Hanny's Voorwerp ("Hanny's Object" in Dutch), an unusual cloud of gas discovered by Dutch amateur astronomer Hanny van Arkel.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 64
Brightest stars 46 Leonis Minoris 3.8, Beta (β) 4.2
Genitive Leonis Minoris
Abbreviation LMi
Highest in sky at 10pm March–April
Fully visible 90°N–48°S



CHART 5

MAIN STARS

Beta (β) Leonis Minoris
 Yellow-orange giant
 ✨ 4.2 ↔ 154 light-years

46 Leonis Minoris
 Orange giant
 ✨ 3.8 ↔ 95 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

IC 2497 and Hanny's Voorwerp
 Active galaxy with nearby gas cloud

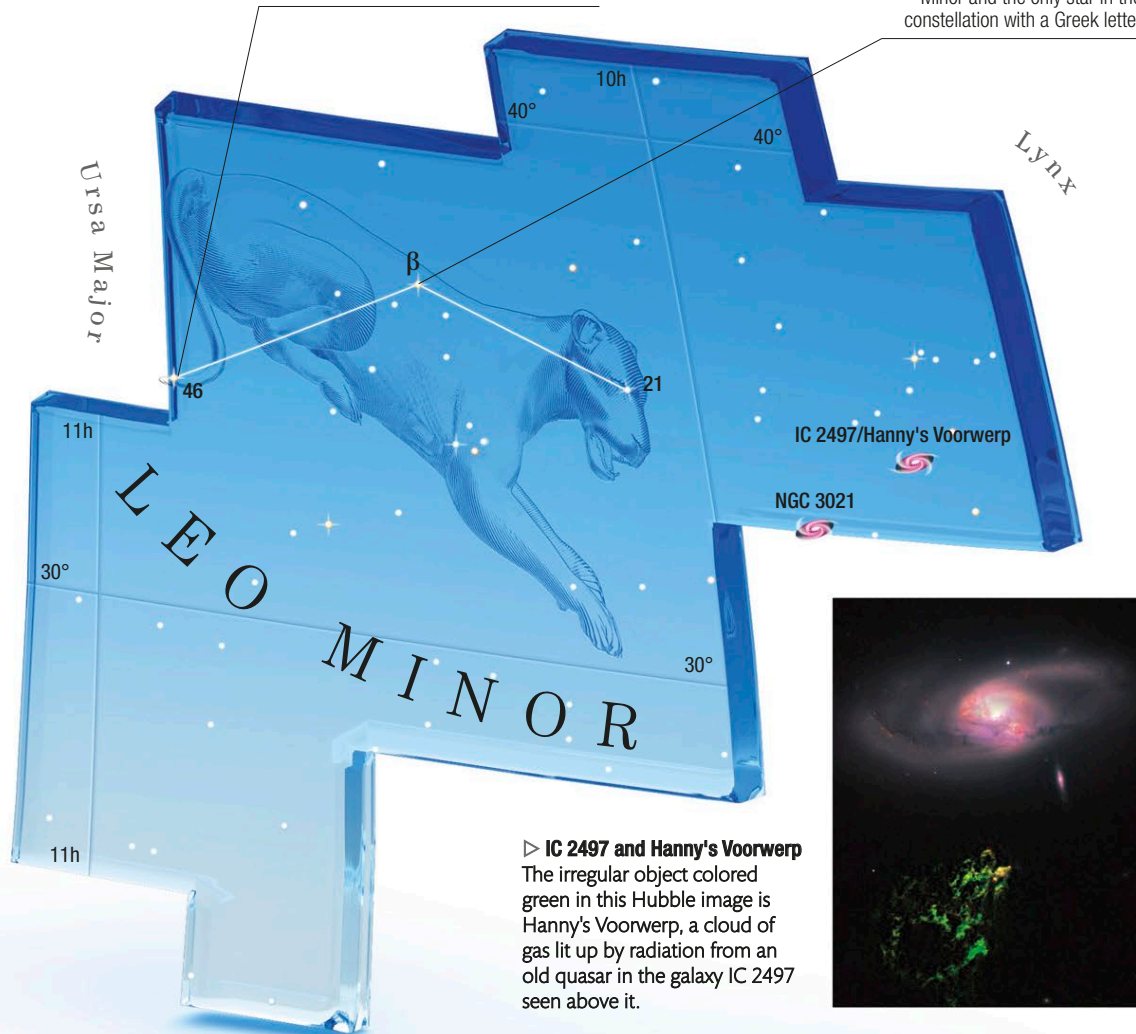
NGC 3021
 Spiral galaxy

46 Leonis Minoris

The brightest star in Leo Minor; an orange giant with a diameter about 8.5 times that of the Sun and a mass of about 1.5 Suns

Beta (β) Leonis Minoris

The 2nd-brightest star in Leo Minor and the only star in the constellation with a Greek letter

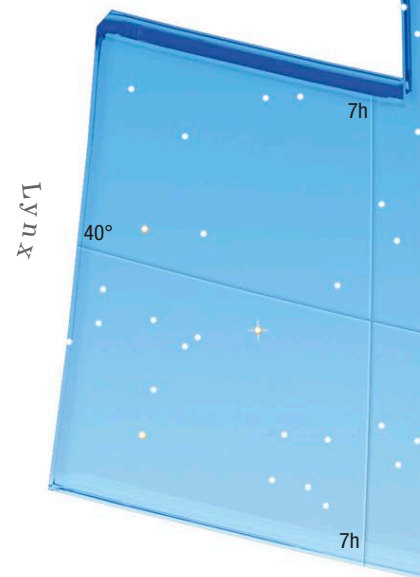


IC 2497 and Hanny's Voorwerp

The irregular object colored green in this Hubble image is Hanny's Voorwerp, a cloud of gas lit up by radiation from an old quasar in the galaxy IC 2497 seen above it.



The main star **Capella** is the **brightest naked-eye star** with the same color as the Sun



AURIGA

THE CHARIOTEER

A LARGE AND PROMINENT CONSTELLATION OF THE NORTHERN SKY, AURIGA CONTAINS THE SIXTH-BRIGHTEST STAR IN THE SKY, CAPELLA.

Auriga represents a charioteer of Greek legend, although the chariot itself is not part of the constellation. Auriga's brightest star, Capella, represents a goat carried by the charioteer. Another notable star is the white supergiant Epsilon Aurigae, which is an eclipsing binary with an exceptionally long period of 27 years. Three open clusters, M36, M37, and M38, can be seen with binoculars. All lie about 4,000 light-years away. M37 is the largest but M36 is the easiest to spot. The star marking the charioteer's right foot was once shared with Taurus. When borders for all the constellations were officially decided in 1930, this star was allocated to Taurus, hence its present-day name of Beta Tauri.